

Australia Daily Brief

Monday, September 14, 2026

1,941 words · 8 min read

RE: UK pushes AUKUS sub order to 2028 · Vanuatu ferry sinks, up to 30 missing · China-linked firm on ADF panel · One Nation targets 750,000 visas · Indian navy chief at Devonport

ASX 200

8,750

-2.90%

AUD/USD

0.7130

-1.26%

NZX 50

13,561

-2.74%

NZD/USD

0.5774

-1.85%

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• TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Britain has pushed its final order for the new AUKUS nuclear submarine fleet out to 2028, three days after a British envoy fielded questions in Australia on UK yard capacity for the SSN-AUKUS timetable.
- 2 Vanuatu's inter-island ferry MV Matui sank between Santo and Ambae with up to thirty people still missing, and the national meteorological service says it issued warnings days ahead but has no power to stop a vessel sailing.
- 3 India's Chief of the Naval Staff inspected a guard of honour at Devonport Naval Base in Auckland, the latest step under the India-New Zealand defence cooperation memorandum signed in 2025.

• TOP STORIES

AUKUS

Britain delays final order for AUKUS submarine fleet until 2028

The United Kingdom has delayed its final order for the new AUKUS nuclear submarine fleet until 2028, a decision The Australian reported under the description "a shambles". The delay lands three days after a British envoy in Australia fielded questions on UK yard capacity for the SSN-AUKUS timetable, an item this brief carried on September 11.

per The Australian: "A shambles": UK delays decision on AUKUS subs"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Vanuatu ferry sinking leaves up to 30 missing, exposes warning gap

The inter-island ferry MV Matui sank in rough seas between Santo and Ambae on Friday, with two deaths confirmed, 15 rescued and up to 30 people still missing. Vanuatu Meteorology and Geo-Hazards Department director **Levu Antfalo** said warnings went out on Tuesday and a marine strong wind warning at 5am Friday forecast seas of up to three metres, but that stopping vessels "is not our mandate". Pilot **Mark Turnbull**, who flew the first aerial search, said help took more than 30 hours to arrive.

per RNZ Pacific: "Vanuatu ferry disaster exposes gap between warnings and action" · also ABC Pacific

AU-DEFENSE

China-linked drone firm appointed to ADF security panel

A drone defence firm with China links has been appointed to a security panel serving the Australian Defence Force, an appointment critics called "alarming". The report does not detail the company's ownership, the panel's remit, or how the selection was made.

per The Australian: "'Alarming': China-linked firm on ADF security panel"

AU-POLITICS

One Nation unveils net-negative migration plan as poll shows two in three back cuts

Pauline Hanson released a migration policy that would cut 750,000 visas over three years, drawing immediate criticism from industry, Labor and the Coalition. The Resolve Political Monitor found two in every three Australians support tough measures to reduce migration. Deputy Liberal leader **Jane Hume** called on One Nation to release the modelling behind the plan, while the government has yet to release its own migration policy after two meetings last week between the Prime Minister and the Opposition Leader.

per Sydney Morning Herald: "Slash the intake: Majority of Australians demand deeper migration cuts" · also Bloomberg

• OVERNIGHT

AU-DEFENSE

[Hunter-class frigate bill reaches \\$27 billion for first three ships](#) · ABC News

Budget documents show close to \$27 billion allocated to building the first three Hunter-class frigates. The lead ship, under construction at Adelaide's Osborne shipyard, recently joined two hull blocks and is due for delivery in 2032, replacing the ageing Anzac-class. Six are planned in total after years of delays and cost growth.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

[Experts warn China-Russia-North Korea cooperation raises risk to Asian security](#) · Sydney Morning Herald

Experts including a former CIA chief warn that security in Asia is under threat as China, Russia and North Korea work more closely on missiles, drones and other technology through the war in Ukraine. The assessment bears directly on the threat picture underpinning Australian force planning.

AU-POLITICS

[Hanson condemned across the parliament for 'primitive race' remarks](#) · ABC News

Resurfaced comments from a podcast last year, in which the One Nation leader called Indigenous Australians "the most primitive race on Earth", drew condemnation from politicians of all parties. Indigenous Australians Minister **Malarndirri McCarthy** called the remarks "derogatory" and "completely racist" and said it was for the Senate to decide on consequences.

TRADE-ECONOMY

Whyalla steelworks to shut blast furnace, more than 500 jobs go · Sydney Morning Herald

The blast furnace at South Australia's Whyalla steelworks will close permanently, ending more than 500 jobs, with over 100 contractors also affected according to ABC reporting. Whyalla is Australia's only maker of structural steel long products and has been the subject of repeated federal and state intervention.

• STAT OF THE DAY

\$27 billion

allocated for the first three Hunter-class frigates

Budget documents put the cost of the first three of six ships close to \$27 billion, with the lead vessel not due until 2032.

ABC News

• PACIFIC WIRE

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · BLOOMBERG

Bougainville vows action after alleged arson at Panguna mine camp

Bougainville authorities pledged action after an alleged arson attack on the Lloyds Metals and Energy Limited camp at Panguna. Papua New Guinea's Minister for International Trade and Investment **Richard Maru** said the national government and the country should not be blamed for the attack, adding that he had warned the company.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG drafts framework for an under-age social media ban

Papua New Guinea's Department of Information and Communications Technology is preparing a framework to determine which platforms are unsuitable for children and require age checks, following Australia's under-16 ban. Secretary **Steven Matainaho** said rules should be ready for public consultation later this year, citing "growing cases of children being exposed to interactions with strangers".

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

PNG first in the Pacific to run disaster risk reduction maturity assessment

Papua New Guinea has become the first Pacific country to undertake the Disaster Risk Reduction Maturity Model assessment, work involving the National Disaster Centre and UNDP Papua New Guinea.

FIJI · RNZ PACIFIC

Researcher calls Fiji infant HIV infections 'horrendously high' as travel warning issued

Victoria University senior health researcher **Sharon McIennan** said about one baby a week is born with HIV in Fiji and about one a month dies of HIV-related complications. An estimated 9,000 Fijians were living with HIV as of March, with needle sharing driving the rise. New Zealand's SafeTravel site now advises travellers to Fiji to avoid activities that raise infection risk, with Fiji's government having declared the epidemic a national crisis.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Fiji sets three COP31 priorities and will host Pacific pre-COP in Nadi

Permanent Secretary for Environment and Climate Change **Sivendra Michael** named keeping 1.5 degrees within reach, fairer climate finance access, and placing the ocean on the negotiating table as Fiji's COP31 priorities. Only three agencies are accredited to receive Green Climate Fund money across all 14 Pacific island countries, he said, while Fiji became the first country able to access the Fund for Loss and Damage without accreditation. Fiji hosts the Pacific pre-COP negotiators meeting in Nadi on October 1 and 2.

FIJI · FIJI SUN

Strong El Niño to peak late 2026 and persist into 2027, met council told

Simon McGree of the Australian Bureau of Meteorology told the 8th Pacific Meteorological Council meeting in Nuku'alofa that oceanic and atmospheric indicators are consistent with a strong El Niño, declared in June and forecast to peak late this year or in early 2027. Most models put the event above the warmest observed since reliable records began in 1950, with effects expected to persist into March to May 2027 and suppressed rainfall in Fiji lingering after the event weakens.

SOLOMON ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Solomon Islands young women's parliamentary group presses for role in security policy

The Solomon Islands Young Women's Parliamentary Group, working on human security and peacebuilding since 2024, argues that women remain significantly underrepresented in formal leadership and parliamentary roles despite their contribution to economic and social stability. The group ties lasting peace to food security, climate resilience and participation in committee consultations and national policy.

SAMOA · SAMOA OBSERVER

Academic warns of parliamentary instability as Samoa joins Pacific assembly

Dr Upolu warned of parliamentary instability in Samoa as the country joins a Pacific parliamentary assembly, the Samoa Observer reported. Further detail was not available in the published account.

● NEW ZEALAND

NZ-DEFENSE · NZDF

Indian navy chief visits Devonport as New Zealand-India defence ties deepen

Chief of the Naval Staff India, Admiral **Krishna Swaminathan**, met New Zealand's Chief of Navy, Rear Admiral **Garin Golding**, at Devonport Naval Base in Auckland on Monday, receiving a guard of honour and a welcome onto the Navy marae Te Taua Moana. The visit follows the India-New Zealand Memorandum of Understanding for Defence Cooperation signed in 2025 by Prime Minister **Christopher Luxon** and Prime Minister **Narendra Modi**, and the Indian Navy's deputy commander role in the New Zealand-led Combined Task Force 150 drug interdiction operations in the Indian Ocean.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Luxon refuses to pause fast-track housing referrals as councils push back

New Zealand's Prime Minister told Morning Report that only 13 housing developments had been approved across the entire fast-track regime and that projects should not be "turned off and on". Local Government New Zealand wants referrals paused pending a review, while Auckland Council faces an infrastructure bill of up to \$5 billion from 50,000 to 60,000 "unanticipated" homes. The government has signalled a law change on council development contributions before the end of the parliamentary term.

NZ-POLITICS · NEWSROOM NZ

National candidate backtracks after telling Newsroom he does not believe in global warming

Asked whether he believed in global warming, National Party candidate **Lloyd Budd** told Newsroom's **Sam Sachdeva**: "I don't think so, no," before walking the remarks back. The exchange lands with New Zealand's

general election set for November 7, and with climate policy a live issue for a country that co-negotiates Pacific climate positions.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

SAMOA · COMMERCIAL PRESENCE · SAMOA OBSERVER

Chinese-owned retail expansion squeezes Samoan village shops

Family-run stores in Leusoali'i, Falevao and Tafagamanu Lefaga report customers shifting to larger retailers, with owners citing bulk-purchasing price gaps they cannot match. The Samoa Observer reports the expansion of Chinese-owned shops and supermarkets has contributed to greater competition in Samoa's retail sector.

• CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Hastie says Australia is losing the AI 'arms race' and risks becoming a supplicant nation

One of the world's leading artificial intelligence companies has said it wants to train its models in Australia as part of the technology "arms race", the Sydney Morning Herald's **Matthew Knott** reports. Liberal MP **Andrew Hastie** argues Australia risks becoming a supplicant nation if it falls behind.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Hanson failed to disclose \$255,000 in One Nation election spending

One Nation did not disclose \$255,000 of election spending, The Australian reports, a disclosure failure surfacing in the same week the party set the national migration debate.

• BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Chevron Australia expects LNG prices to stay high for six months

Chevron's Australian arm expects elevated liquefied natural gas prices to persist for about six months. Brent crude sits at 107.54, up 6.25 percent, amid attacks on Gulf and Red Sea energy infrastructure.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFR

Former RBA board member says the board splits at one meeting in three

Ian Harper, a former Reserve Bank of Australia board member, said there has been "vigorous debate" around the table over the past decade, with the board split on rate decisions at roughly one meeting in three. The cash rate stands at 4.35 percent after a unanimous hold on August 11.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Business projects Australia's worst decade on record for productivity

Business projections point to the weakest decade of productivity growth on record under the Treasurer's policy settings, The Australian reports. The paper separately reports the government blaming external factors for the slowdown.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

Data centre firm Firmus said to seek \$5 billion in Australian IPO

Firmus is reported to be seeking \$5 billion in an Australian initial public offering, a listing that would test investor appetite for domestic compute infrastructure as AI companies look at training models onshore.

• UPCOMING

OCT
1

Pacific pre-COP negotiators meeting, Nadi, October 1 and 2

Pacific states finalise their official negotiating positions for COP31, including Fiji's push to put the ocean formally on the agenda.

OCT
26

Advance voting opens for the New Zealand general election

Campaign positions on climate, housing and defence harden once voting starts.

NOV
7

New Zealand general election

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues to set New Zealand's foreign and defence policy.

MAR
2027

Forecast persistence of strong El Niño impacts across the Pacific

Suppressed rainfall lingering past the event's peak shapes water, health and disaster planning in Fiji and neighbouring states.

• THE WIRE

PACIFIC-POLITICS

FIJI SUN

Fiji social media ban for under-16s heads to Cabinet

Minister for Information **Lynda Tabuya** said a report and draft legislation banning social media for children aged 16 and under will go to Cabinet, following consultations with children aged 13 to 17 across five locations in Nasinu, Qauia and Namosi.

ABC NEWS

PNG girls to receive HPV vaccine for the first time

A new immunisation programme will give girls in Papua New Guinea access to the HPV vaccine, developed in Australia, where cervical cancer is among the leading causes of cancer deaths in women.

AU-POLITICS

AFR

UK MP Johnny Mercer defends Hastie as 'a true patriot, not a traitor'

British MP **Johnny Mercer** writes that he is baffled by the "othering" of loyalty to ANZAC values by "the loud, pernicious, attention-seeking and weak", intervening in the Australian row between the Liberal MP and One Nation.

TRADE-ECONOMY

PNG POST-COURIER

Wood wins US\$200 million five-year contract with ExxonMobil PNG

Engineering and consulting firm Wood has secured a US\$200 million, five-year construction services contract from ExxonMobil PNG, extending its role in one of Papua New Guinea's largest resource developments.

BLOOMBERG

Australian skiers drive New Zealand tourist arrivals to a July record

Australian ski visitors pushed New Zealand's July tourist arrivals to a record, underlining the weight of the trans-Tasman market in New Zealand's services trade.

• ANALYSIS AND OPINION

ASPI STRATEGIST

Australia should look to Norway for ways to build national resilience

The piece argues Norwegian preparedness extends well beyond the armed forces into civil structures, and that Australia can draw on that model as it operationalises the resilience language in its own defence policy.

Argument: Australia, having named national resilience and civil preparedness as central to national defence, should study Norway, which has organised around those concepts for decades.

ASPI STRATEGIST

AI is going to change everything. Australia should help steer that change

Written ahead of ASPI's Sydney Dialogue AI Masterclass, the piece urges attendees to consider readiness for systems that exceed human intelligence.

Argument: Australia should shape the governance of artificial intelligence rather than react to it, starting with whether the country is prepared for AI smarter than humans.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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